Scientists date oldest wildfire
Scientists find oldest wildfires dating back 430 million years
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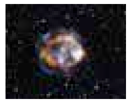

Dead Star killing planets
Dead Star G238-44 observed through Hubble ripping apart its own planetary system
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Plastitar
Earth's Newest Pollutant

Plastic and Tar have found a way to merge.

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On the biggest coast of the Canary Islands, near the east coast of Tenerife, you can appreciate fine sand along with the clear waters. You might even see a black, hot and rather squishy rock. Sounds good, right? Not when you find out that it's really an alarming new breed of pollutant.

The word 'plastitar' was coined by Javier Hernández-Borges, an associate scientist of analytical chemistry at the University of La Laguna in Tenerife. If you hadn't come across this term before this, it is because it's a relatively new discovery. Its existence came to light when researchers found 'rocks' of hardened tar with plastic sprinkled on top. Plastic is no longer just found in its more familiar forms in the environment – bottles, packets or other forms of microplastic. When combined with tar, (a common occurrence on beaches) it becomes a newer and much more harmful material. This knowledge gives way to an even more scary realisation that plastic could cause other similar formations.

Plastitar occurs when oil spills hang around long enough to evaporate and leave behind hardened tar. The tar then sticks to rock and will attract any plastic present near the shores. Hernández-Borges says that this tar acts like Play-Doh, attracting plastic and other marine waste. This attraction doesn't just apply to plastics, though. Any form of debris can get attached to the tar and give rise to plastitar. The algae living on the rocks that are covered by tar will die; and though it's too soon to give the definitive effects of plastitar, living creatures in its proximity could potentially cease to exist.

Images of plastitar formations can be found on the rocky shores of Playa Grande. In the photographs taken here, it is clear that a large number of microplastics (mesoplastics, to a smaller extent, can also be characterised) have been ingrained in the tar matrix, which comprises a broad surface area, as well as pieces of wood or coarse sand. Since the characteristics and properties of this new formation differ significantly from those reported earlier as plastiglomerates, pyroplastics, plasticrusts and anthropoquinas, the name 'plastitar' was proposed, incorporating its two major components.

During the sampling campaigns on the beaches of Arenas Blancas and Playa Grande, large amounts of